

filing deadline rather than early. There's some evidence that people who file early may have a greater chance of being randomly selected for audit.

What to Do If You're Audited

During an audit you'll be asked to substantiate certain items by producing receipts or other proof. You may be able to do this by mail. If the IRS requests a face-to-face audit, you have the right to have a representative (your accountant or tax preparer) attend with you or in your place. If you attend, keep your emotions under control, don't volunteer any information, and don't act defensive. Treat the agent respectfully. Have all of the requested documents with you and organized in a logical manner. It may be best to let your representative answer all questions or meet with the IRS agent without you. If your representative can't answer a question, he will ask you later and get back to the agent.



ESSENTIAL

For everything you always wanted to know about federal income taxes but were afraid to ask, see the IRS's surprisingly user-friendly website, www.irs.gov.
